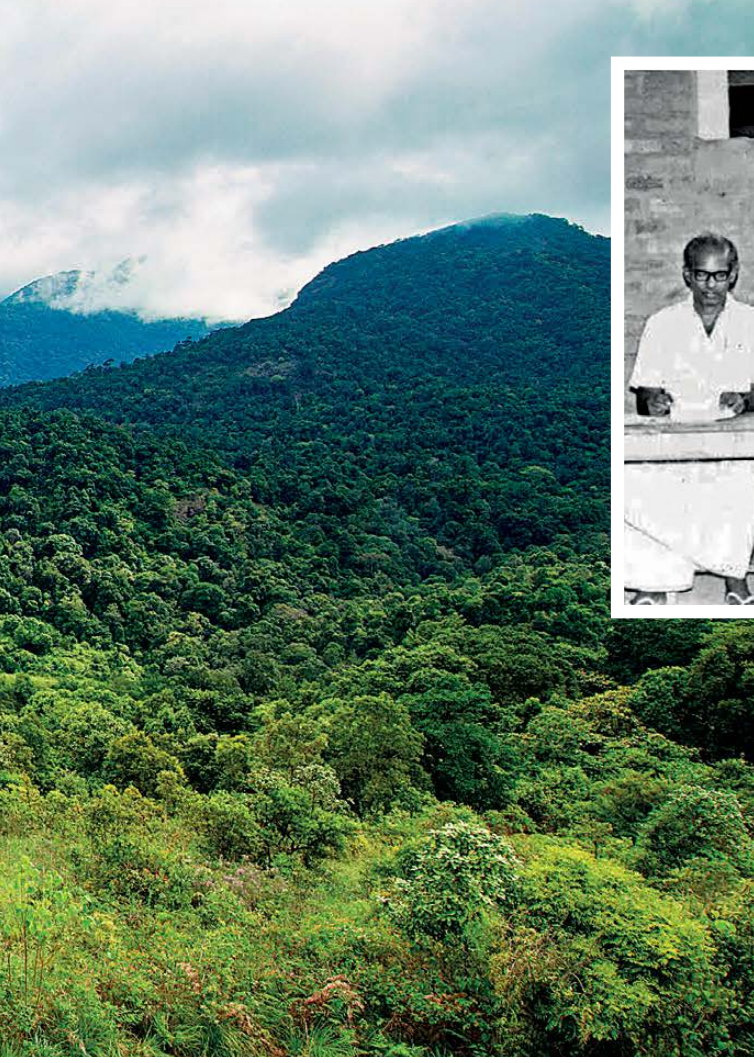


ALAMY



COURTESY: KSSP

A UNIQUE MOVEMENT
A view of Silent Valley in Kerala's Palakkad district; Top, a Kerala Sasthra Sahitya Parishad environment protection meeting, 1984

The movement had solid scientific opinion on its side—experts like Steven Green from the New York Zoological Society and herpetologist Romulus Whitaker had revealed early on that the dam would cause irreparable damage to endangered species like the lion-tailed macaque, which later emerged as the face of the movement. In 1976, a task force appointed by the Centre's National Committee on Environment Planning and Coordination recommended stopping the project but also left caveats that it could be saved with 'safeguards' to reduce damage. As the state held its ground, a plangent cry rang out across the nation: 'Save Silent Valley'.

Through the '70s, the cause of the Silent Valley was championed by many exemplary activists including Sathish Chandran Nair, Prof. John Jacob and S. Prabhakaran Nair who spread awareness in the hill villages and mobilised young naturalists. As opinion columns consolidated mass opinion, people wrote letters in national dailies and 'tree poets' read their poetry in public. Taking note, the general assembly of the International Union for Conservation of Nature (IUCN) requested the Indian government to reconsider the project.

Despite the protests, the Moraraji Desai government at the Centre pushed through with it in 1979. But public awareness generated enough pressure for a new government—headed by Indira Gandhi—to stop and think. In 1980, a nine-member central fact-finding committee headed by scientist and policy maker M.G.K. Menon recommended that the project be scrapped. In 1981, Silent Valley was declared a protected area and in 1983 the hydropower project was finally called off. The long struggle was won. ■

LAWS OF NATURE

» **It set a precedent for environmental activism in India, demonstrating how common people could pressure governments to preserve the environment through non-violent movements**

» **It instilled the lesson that unchecked development for urban needs at the cost of nature did not serve humanity well**

» **The need to engage local communities as core stakeholders in greenfield projects continues to be the cornerstone of policymaking**